

Correlative Conjunctions Practice—Answer Key

Practice 1: Choose the correct pair of correlative conjunctions to complete each sentence. In some cases, more than one pair may be possible. If that is the case, select only 1. The first one is done for you.

a. both...and	b. not only...but also	c. either...or	d. neither...nor
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1. ____ my sister ____ brother are married with children.

A--Notice the plural verb “are”. This means it cannot be “not only...but also”, “either...or” or “neither...nor”.

2. Julie eats ____ red meat ____ chicken because she is a vegetarian.

D--We know that Julie does NOT eat red meat or chicken because she is a vegetarian. “Neither...nor” expresses this negation.

3. The mother told her child that he could have ____ ice cream ____ cookies for dessert, but not both.

C--“Either...or” implies one or the other, but not both.

4. If you would like to receive dual citizenship, ____ your mother ____ your father had to have been born in another country. For example, Mary’s mom is from Spain, and her Dad is from the U.S., which means that she has dual citizenship!

C--“Either...or” implies one or the other, but not both.

5. ____ does the school accept international students ____ it offers them a special scholarship.

B--You know that you need “not only...but also” because you see the helping verb “does” and the correlative conjunctions precede two clauses.

6. After a long day at work, John is so tired that he can ____ cook dinner ____ exercise. Instead, he watches TV and picks up some fast food.

D--It is easy to see that John does not cook dinner and he does not exercise.

7. The strict teacher said that students can ____ chew gum ____ use electronics during class.

D--The teacher is strict, so he does NOT allow students to chew gum or use electronics. The keyword is “strict”.

8. Gary wants to be a triathlete, but there is just one problem. He can ____ ride a bike ____ run very well, but he does not know how to swim.

A OR B--Because this sentence contains the conjunction “but”, we know that the two clauses should be contrastive. He CAN ride a bike and run, but he CANNOT swim.

9. ____ New York ____ California host popular beaches.

A--When correlating two subjects with “both...and”, the verb is always agrees with a plural subject. This is not true with the other correlative conjunctions, which follow the rule of the verb agreeing with the closest subject.

10. ____ students ____ the teacher works very hard to prepare for each class; it is a combined effort!

B--Notice the verb “works” agrees with “teacher”. If it were “both...and”, the verb would have to be “work”.

Practice 2: Put the words in order to make a sentence with correlative conjunctions.

1. attending/ be/ her/ husband/ neither/ nor/ party/ the/ Sarah / will

Neither Sarah nor her husband will be attending the party.

2. accommodation/ also/ but/ deal /includes/ only/ food/not/ the/ vacation

The vacation deal includes not only accommodation but also food.

OR The vacation deal includes not only food but also accommodation.

3. are/ and/ both/ develop/ grammar/ important/ vocabulary/ skills/ to

Both grammar and vocabulary are important skills to develop.

OR Both vocabulary and grammar are important skills to develop.

4. by/ can/ car/or/ travelers / get / train / there/ either

Travelers can get there by either car or by train.

OR Travelers can get there by either train or car.

5. also/ but/ inspiring/ music/ entertaining/ only/ is/ to / listening/ not

Listening to music is not only entertaining but also inspiring.

OR Listening to music is not only inspiring but also entertaining.

6. anger/ hatred/ neither/ problems/ nor/ solves

Neither hatred nor anger solves problems.

OR Neither anger nor hatred solves problems.

7. be/ can/ day/ either/ every/ happy/ to/ or/ we/ unhappy/ choose

Every day we can choose to be either happy or unhappy.

OR Every day we can choose to be either unhappy or happy.

8. a/ a/ blessing/ both/ burden/ is/ technology/ and

Technology is both a blessing and a burden.

OR Technology is both a burden and a blessing.

9. a/ a/ a/ either/ bad/ good/ familiar/ up/ conjure/ memory/ scent/ may/ memory/ or

A familiar scent may conjure up either a good memory or a bad memory.

OR A familiar scent may conjure up either a bad memory or a good memory.

10. accusation/ deny/ neither/ will/ I / your/ confirm/ nor/ your

I will neither confirm nor deny your accusation.

OR I will neither deny or confirm your accusation.